

Trend Analysis

Scan macro shifts shaping future user needs

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Trend Analysis systematically scans social, technological, economic, environmental and political shifts to anticipate how user needs and contexts will change. It grounds design decisions in where the world is heading, not only where users are today.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Drawn from strategic-foresight and futures-studies practice; embedded in design toolkits such as the Design Thinking Toolbox.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Designing only for present needs risks solutions that are obsolete at launch. Scanning trends helps teams design for emerging rather than expiring needs.

HOW IT IS USED

Teams gather signals across STEEP categories, cluster them into trends, assess relevance and timing, and translate implications into design principles or 'how might we' prompts.

WHEN IT IS USED

Front-end of a project, alongside empathy research, and in visioning for longer-horizon innovation.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Strategists, innovation teams, service designers and product planners.

FIGURE 1 · STEEP TREND RADAR

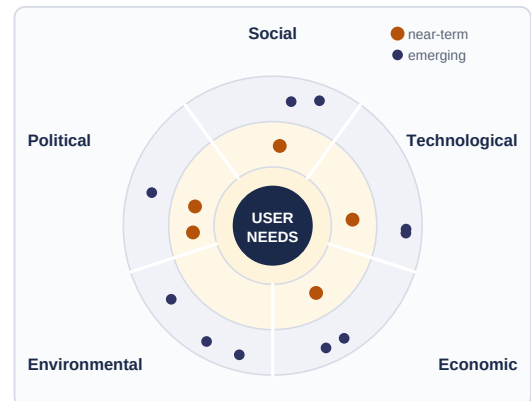


Figure 1. Social, technological, economic, environmental and political shifts plotted by proximity to user needs.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It widens empathy from the **individual user to the moving context** around them, connecting human-centred design to strategic foresight.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Vision Cone *Slibrary 6*

Context Mapping *Slibrary 6*

AEIOU *Slibrary 5*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Lewrick, M., Link, P. and Leifer, L. (2020) *The Design Thinking Toolbox*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.

Hines, A. and Bishop, P. (2013) *Teaching about the Future*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.